

María de los Ángeles Lasa, PhD

Applied Data Science · Computational Social Science

Buenos Aires, Argentina · marialasa.ar/#portfolio · linkedin.com/in/marialasa

Profile

Political Data Scientist with 10+ years of experience in mixed-methods research and applied analytics. I design and implement data- and AI-driven tools that help CSOs, international organizations, and governments measure, evaluate, and communicate the impact of their programs. I translate complex analysis for non-technical audiences and facilitate evidence-based decision-making. Published author, international speaker, and university lecturer.

Professional experience

Applied Data Science Manager · Global Fund for Women

Dec 2022 – Ongoing

Gender Justice Data Hub · Remote for San Francisco, United States

- Designed and built GAIA, a conversational assistant with a RAG architecture for exploring the narrative reports of grantee partners. I implemented the full pipeline, including cleaning and preparing the corpus, the chunking strategy, the multilingual embeddings, the vector database, and the generation layer. I also developed a systematic evaluation strategy covering answer faithfulness and retrieval relevance.
- Built from scratch the analytical stack of the Gender Justice Data Hub and designed in-house instruments for detecting and monitoring gender justice movements. These include the *Social Movements Index*, which measures the intensity and persistence of social mobilization across 195 countries using ACLED data; the *Peak Detection Algorithm*, which identifies unusual spikes in protest activity; and the *Agendas Mapper*, which detects emerging thematic patterns through unsupervised machine learning. Together, these tools informed the grantmaking process and contributed to directing USD 1.5 million in funding to gender justice movements across 20+ countries.

Project Consultant · Independent Consulting

Dec 2022 – Ongoing

Buenos Aires, Argentina

- Provide consulting services in evaluation, data analytics, and research methodology, supporting organizations in the design of evidence-based programs and measurement frameworks. Clients include Waverley Street Foundation, If Not Us Then Who?, Movilizadorio, Government of the Province of Córdoba, and Somus HR.

Director of Legacy and Sustainability · XIX Pan American Games Santiago 2023

May – Dec 2022

Executive Office · Santiago, Chile

- Defined the mega-event's legacy and sustainability strategy, together with its measurement framework, in coordination with internal functional areas and public-sector counterparts. The strategy earned Santiago 2023 the *Energy Efficiency Bronze Award* from the Chilean Ministry of Energy (2022).

Research and Data Analysis Manager · Movilizadorio

Apr 2020 – Apr 2022

Projects Division · Remote for Bogotá, Colombia

- Led the research and data strategy for projects on disinformation, media literacy, judicial protection of migrants, polarization, political participation, and anti-vaccine movements for philanthropic organizations, international agencies, and clients, including Google News Initiative, USAID, Climate and Land Use Alliance, Chemonics, and GlaxoSmithKline.
- Co-led the technical design of a pioneering study of political polarization in Colombia, combining K-means clustering with the Moral Foundations Theory. The study was conducted in partnership with More in Common and funded by the Ford Foundation, the Open Society Foundations, and the Embassy of Canada in Colombia.

Data Analyst · Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development

Jul – Sep 2019

Open Government Unit · Paris, France

Project Consultant · Oxford Development Consultancy

Oct 2018 – Mar 2019

Oxford, United Kingdom

Legacy and Sustainability Manager · Youth Olympic Games BA2018

Apr 2017 – Sep 2018

Corporate Planning Department · Buenos Aires, Argentina

Education

Master of Public Policy

2018 – 2019

University of Oxford, United Kingdom. GPA: 63. Final report: Merit.

PhD in Political Science

2011 – 2014

Università degli Studi di Camerino, Italy. PhD Dissertation: Ottimo.

BA in International Relations

2005 – 2009

Universidad Católica de Córdoba (UCC-Jesuitas), Argentina. GPA: 9.05/10. Distinction.

Additional training

10+ postgraduate programs and summer schools in Argentina, Chile, Spain, the United States, and Israel. Selected programs relevant to computational methods and public policy analysis:

Postgraduate Diploma in Artificial Intelligence School of Engineering, Universidad Austral, Argentina	Mar – Sep 2026
Summer School in Mixed Methods Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile	Jan 2025
Postgraduate Diploma in Computational Social Science Universidad Nacional de San Martín, Argentina	Apr – Dec 2024
Postgraduate Diploma in Big Data and Territorial Intelligence FLACSO Argentina	Apr – Dec 2023
Oxford-Blavatnik Policy Program Tel Aviv University, Israel	Mar 2019
Postgraduate Diploma in Public Policy Design and Evaluation Universitat Pompeu Fabra, Spain	Mar – Dec 2017

Technical skills

Programming languages: Python, R, SQL, LaTeX, HTML.

AI and NLP: LLMs and prompting, RAG systems, multilingual embeddings, vector databases, multi-label text classification, topic modeling.

Machine learning: supervised and unsupervised learning, regression and classification models, clustering (K-means), anomaly detection, feature engineering, and computer vision.

Data and visualization: BigQuery, Power BI, Tableau, Flourish, Gephi, SPSS, and advanced Excel.

Methods: mixed-methods research design, inferential statistics, impact evaluation, sampling, network analysis, spatial analysis, and time series.

Teaching and research

15+ years of teaching, research, and thesis supervision in quantitative methods, computational text analysis, data science for public decision-making, and International Relations at universities in Argentina, Colombia, Mexico, Paraguay, the United Kingdom, and the United States. Selected appointments:

Universidad Nacional de La Plata, Argentina Lecturer on the MA in International Relations and associate researcher at the Center for Korean Studies.	2025 – Ongoing
Instituto Tecnológico de Monterrey, Mexico Training partner for <i>Data Science for Decision-Making II</i> , Program in Government and Public Transformation.	2024 – Ongoing
Universidad de San Andrés, Argentina Teaching assistant and co-supervisor of undergraduate dissertations in quantitative methods.	Aug – Dec 2025
Universidad Comunera, Paraguay Lecturer in Pol.Sci. for Public Policy, Postgraduate Diploma in Public Policy. Student evaluation: 4.90/5.	2020 – 2025
Universidad Torcuato Di Tella, Argentina Visiting lecturer in State and Public Policy in Argentina. Student evaluation: 4.55/5.	2021 – 2022

Additional information

Publications: author of “País de vinalón: mi viaje a Corea del Norte” (CADAL, 2024; Eduvim, 2025), as well as articles in peer-reviewed journals, book chapters, and press pieces in outlets from Argentina, South Korea, and the United Kingdom.

International speaker: speaker at TEDxRecoleta, TEDxUCC, WiDS 2023, csv.conf.v8, and Nerdearla. Presenter at 30+ conferences and forums in Argentina, Belgium, Chile, Colombia, Italy, Mexico, Peru, Sweden, Switzerland, and the United States.

Awards: Ten Outstanding Young Persons of Argentina, JCI (2023). Honorable Mention, XXXVI Luis José de Tejeda Literature Prize (2023). Research Excellence Prize, Università degli Studi di Camerino (2013). 3rd prize, St. Gallen Wings of Excellence Award (2011). 1st prize, World Bank *Ideas4Action* Competition (2010). 2nd prize, World Bank International Essay Competition (2010).

Scholarships: Fundación Carolina, Fulbright, Consorzio Universitario Italiano per l'Argentina, Chevening, Blavatnik School of Government, Erasmus+.

Affiliations: Center for the Opening and Development of Latin America (CADAL). Chevening Alumni Argentina. Argentine Society of Political Analysis (SAAP). Oxford Union Society. MERL Tech. Red de Politólogos.

Languages: Spanish (native). English (advanced, IELTS 7.5). Italian (intermediate, B2).